



Turning Friends Into Objects: A Letter Struggling With Analytic Distance in the New Latino Diaspora

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Ethnographic research requires that social scientists build relationships with the people whose lives they describe. Sometimes these relationships become friendships. Disseminating the results of that research typically requires analytic distance, however, describing these same people in ways that one would not do with other friends. How can ethnographers do both things at once—build ethical and human relationships with research participants while also describing these people’s lives and contexts in scientifically useful ways? This contribution addresses the question with reference to a decade-long ethnographic project which included both research and friendship. It describes the developing relationship between an ethnographer and a family of Mexican immigrants to the U.S., illustrating the tension between scientist and friend.

Keywords: ethnography, linguistic anthropology, relationships, Latino, interviews

Dear Juana and Araceli,

I have valued our friendship over the decade that we have known each other, and I am grateful for the welcome that you and your family have extended to me and my family across the years. Now that I have moved away and ended my work in your town, I am writing a book to communicate some of the things that I learned from you and others. Writing this book has been rewarding, and it has offered an opportunity to remember the many times that we were able to enjoy each other’s company. But it has also created some tensions and misgivings, and I wanted to share these with you.

Ethnographic research requires that social scientists like me build relationships with the people whose lives they describe. Sometimes these relationships become friendships, as they have for us. Disseminating the results of that research typically requires analytic distance, however, in which a social scientist like me describes people like you in ways that one would not do with other friends. How can ethnographers

like me do both things at once—build ethical and human relationships with research participants while also describing your lives and contexts in scientifically useful ways?

The central issue here is a tension between two types of human activities involved in research with people. Many phenomena of interest to social scientists require a whole human being to be the measuring instrument (Powdermaker, 1966). We cannot understand complex human processes using simpler instruments like thermometers, surveys, or exams. Thus we have to use ethnography, which requires a human to serve as the instrument through which we gain access to people’s understandings of their experience. As whole human beings, researchers inevitably build relationships with the participants they hope to understand. These relationships are essential to collecting the evidence necessary for our social scientific research. The relationships involve emotionally, ethically laden actions and connections, and sometimes they grow into genuine friendships—as they have done for us.

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But research also requires a product, some writing or presentation, in which relevant processes are represented. This presupposes a different kind of relationship between researcher and participants, one of knower and known or subject and object. The tension between these two types of relationships—human to human, on the one hand, and subject to object on the other—can produce dissonance and strain.

Many scholars have written about the psychological, philosophical, and ethical issues raised by this tension. [Lather \(2007\)](#), for example, provides a detailed examination of the human relationships and ethical challenges involved in qualitative research. She has also written experimental ethnographies designed to incorporate the voices of research participants in ways that do not present participants as mere objects of research (e.g., [Lather & Smithies, 1997](#)), and others have written in similar ways (e.g., [Dwyer, 1982](#)). This represents one way of overcoming the tension between human relationships and objective representation, a solution in which participants become partners in the production of knowledge. [Crapanzano \(1980\)](#) reflects on the psychological complexities of fieldwork and provides another approach to ethnography that reframes the relationship between ethnographer and participant, by providing a written account that oscillates between personal engagement and analytic distance. [Hume and Mulcock \(2004\)](#) offer a collection of case studies that illustrate the emotional and ethical challenges of fieldwork with human subjects across a range of settings; [Modan \(2016\)](#) explores the complexities of fieldwork relationships in the age of internet-mediated communication. Like many others who have reflected on this challenge, they offer varied ways to manage the tension between human relationship and scientific representation. In this brief letter, I do not have space to say more about these psychological, philosophical, and ethical issues in depth. Instead, I would like to reflect on these complexities by telling a story about the fieldwork I conducted across 11 years with you and your fellow Mexican immigrants to the U.S.

When I began working in the town I call “Marshall,” in order to keep it anonymous, it had as you know only recently become home to thousands of Mexican immigrants. The town’s population was between 30,000 and 35,000. In 1990, 100 of those residents had been Mexican—including, centrally, your extended family. By the

year 2000, there were 2,000 Mexicans. By 2010, there were well over 6,000. Mexicans went from being less than 1% of the population in 1990 to over one-quarter in 2016, the year I completed my fieldwork. That year, 37% of the children in Marshall public schools were Mexican or Mexican American. After Marshall’s founding by English and German settlers two centuries ago, Irish immigrants arrived in the 19th century, followed by two waves of Italian immigrants in the 20th century. You know many of the Irish and Italian Americans who remained in town as residents, landlords, or business owners. Smaller groups of Puerto Rican, South Asian, and Caribbean newcomers settled in Marshall, starting about 40 years ago, though most moved on quickly. Your town’s African-American population began with some arrivals at the end of the 19th century, but most African-American residents or their ancestors arrived in the decades after World War II. The population changed significantly between 1990 and 2010—from 70% White, 25% African-American, and 3% Latino in 1990 to 32% White, 35% African-American, and 28% Latino in 2010. This rapid demographic change meant that Marshall residents had more fluid views about you and other Mexicans than one finds in national discourse and in areas of traditional Latino settlement. Because the Mexican population was so new in this location, both immigrants and longstanding residents had more flexibility in identifying each other ([Wortham et al., 2009](#)).

When your family and other Mexican immigrants came to Marshall, they disrupted a relatively stable ethnic landscape. One feature of this landscape was the presence of “Blacks” and “Whites,” with familiar American racial stereotypes and struggles for power in town government and other institutions. Another feature was the division of the Catholic community between Irish and Italian-origin parishes, with Italians having arrived more recently than the Irish and feeling disempowered in some respects. As you experienced and described to me, Mexicans did not fit neatly into these familiar divisions. My 11-year project in Marshall explored processes of social identification and interethnic relations in the town (e.g., [Clonan-Roy et al., 2016](#); [Nichols & Wortham, 2018](#); [Wortham et al., 2020](#)). As more and more Mexicans moved to Marshall, both longstanding residents and your fellow immigrants asked and answered

questions such as: What types of people are the immigrants and the hosts? Why have Mexicans settled here? How do they relate to other groups in town? What will their role be in the town's future?

In 2007, I was fortunate to meet you—members of the first Mexican family to settle in the town. You described how you and five of your siblings immigrated several decades ago because Juana married a Marshall resident whom she met while he was visiting her hometown as a tourist. You have invited me to many gatherings with you and your siblings, your children, and grandchildren. Early in our relationship you began to invite me and my research assistants to your houses. These were long, casual, friendly events in Juana's or Araceli's yard, with dozens of siblings, cousins, and friends. Coming from a sparse and emotionally reserved family, I had never experienced such warmth and intensity of connection in a family setting before. You welcomed me like one of your longstanding friends and were always happy to see me. You welcomed my children, and my children's friends, even letting my son do an internship at one of the family businesses. You came to my house and tried to teach me how to dance, and your brother catered many events both at my home and my office. I remain grateful for the warmth and human connection that you offered.

It is important to provide a sense of your family in your own words. The following extended excerpt comes from a conversation I had with the two of you in Araceli's kitchen. You told me about your early experiences as immigrants and how you felt "inferior" because you did not speak English well and because you had to do menial jobs like cleaning others' toilets.

Juana: Because I didn't speak the language, I felt bad. Being an educated person in Mexico, I thought I knew English. I knew I could learn English better. So I had to do something to assimilate to American life. I decided to find a way, and I went to Blake County Community College. There I had the aptitude such that they accepted me so I could study ESL, English as a Second Language. So it was about 1985. I was learning in '85, '86. I

learned, I tried to talk, to learn the language. It was difficult for me, but even so, I knew I had the capability to study here, to be something. I couldn't be in the house anymore with nothing to do. Due to the fact that I didn't work, I could dedicate myself to studying and learning the language. Having time, I set myself to study, do homework, set myself to listen to cassettes. I went to the BlakeCo library and I brought back cassettes to listen to at home. So there I learned to read and to write, but also watching television. I studied better listening to and watching soap operas. I was fascinated with General Hospital.

Araceli: (laughter)

J: and all the actors. I was, I felt I learned watching the soap operas. And it was a difficult life. Well then Fred [her American husband] had a 4 year-old daughter. For me it was really difficult to have a stepdaughter—in Spanish it's "hijastra," stepdaughter. The girl being American, and me being Mexican, it wasn't an easy situation to adapt to here because I felt like the girl already knew everything, and me, being older, I didn't know anything. So I wanted, I don't know if it was a competition that I had with the girl—it was Fred's daughter, and I felt a little inferior. Being Mexican and not knowing anyone, I felt inferior, and I felt I had to overcome that feeling. Besides, it's a situation, when you have a stepdaughter at home, it's difficult to live together and above all being from another culture. It was really difficult for me.

A: At first, when we started to work cleaning houses, it was a very difficult stage for us because we had never cleaned.

- J: Yes
- A: Not at all. (laughter)
- J: We *had* someone to clean for us!
- A: Someone who cleaned for us. (laughter)
- J: In our house we had maids.
- A: And there were two or three girls that my mom had. For us, it was a, like-
- J: A very low level.
- A: A very low level.
- J: It was below our way of life. It was beneath us, to clean houses.
- A: But-
- J: For a long time I didn't want Fred's family to know.
- A: It pained us that our family in Mexico might find out that we were cleaning houses, because it was something very-
- J: Very beneath us. (laughter)
- A: And it was shameful. (laughs)
- J: Yes, yes.
- A: But at the same time now it's something different because we can, we have overcome it.
- J: Now we can laugh (laughter) at the embarrassments we went through.
- A: It has been a good experience because considering how difficult it was, because we learned to, to communicate with people, we learned how to live. Because to see how the people lived where we cleaned was something, was something.
- J: A good lesson.
- A: A good lesson, because we said, "How can they live like this, so filthy!" (laughter) "The Americans, how can they live like this?" We would never live like that.
- J: Yes.
- A: And it was a lesson because they live differently. They are very different.
- J: We cleaned very expensive houses. Where the people had a lot of money, and they lived really filthy. So then we learned to, to recognize (A: to value) what we didn't want for ourselves. We want that car, but I'm going to clean that car. We want that house, that kitchen, but I'm going to keep my kitchen clean. Well, we mustn't talk bad, but-
- A: But it was an experience that, that makes it possible to say we overcame because now it doesn't bother me to say, "Alright, I did that to survive." But, yes, in the moment it was something that we couldn't live with. It was humiliating because, because we had never done it, and at the beginning we had to take it because we didn't know how to speak, we didn't know how to communicate, we didn't have anything. We had absolutely no money, not even to pay rent or whatever, and everything came out of that.
- J: When I invited Carolina [their sister] to come here, I told her, "Do you want to come here to earn money? Do you want to come to the United States? But you're going to have to clean 'tazitas'." I told her, "The work we do is cleaning 'tazitas'." Taza, bowl. Toilet bowl, in Spanish, is 'taza,' 'taza de baño,' but she thought 'tazitas,' like coffee cups. She never thought that I was talking about toilet bowls. So she said, "Oh, yes, sure!"

Then I told her, “You’re going to earn” (laughter), I said, “You’re going to earn \$10 an hour!” \$10 at that time we were making. But we ended up making up to \$20 an hour cleaning toilets, ‘tazitas.’ (laughter) So the money you earn over in Mexico, is what? \$5 a day.

A: A day.

J: Here we’re earning \$10 an hour. So obviously it caught her attention and she said, “Yes, yes. I’m going to clean ‘tazitas’, why not.” But she was a teacher in Mexico. She, she worked as an elementary and high school teacher.

A: High school.

J: High school. So, so she arrived here to clean toilets. It was totally humiliating for her. She suffered more than any of us because she arrived here older. Our sister Carolina was already about 34, 35 years old when she came. And to come with the stature of a teacher, in Mexico they really respect teachers. They have- they are respected. And here she comes to clean bathrooms, that was totally shocking for her. How do you say? Traumatic. So she didn’t know how to use a vacuum cleaner. She didn’t know because it was totally different. She didn’t clean her house. She had someone to clean her house. In her house. So to come here and clean for other people was totally ugly, bad. She didn’t know how to use the Lysol spray, she didn’t know Windex. So when she did like this (motions) with the Windex, she sprayed her face. So it was really ugly. Oh, and the people talked to her, but really bad. She suffered much more.

A: She felt that she was being talked to, that they didn’t treat her well

and it was humiliating, and it- and that pained us because we said, “How, how is it possible that we have to do this to survive?” But thank God we had work.

This passage communicates something about you and your family. You were always thoughtful, articulate, and self-aware. You had persevered through hardships, and you had a balanced view of your past. You were also funny, and you were fun to be around.

In addition, the passage provides some evidence about my relationship with you. For example, you trusted me enough to speak about your experiences cleaning toilets early in your time in America and sharing your feelings of humiliation. I had built a strong relationship with you by attending many family barbecues, and by inviting your family to my house and to local restaurants for dinner as well. My students and I were regular guests at your brother’s restaurant, and I used his catering service for several gatherings that I hosted. My son did a month-long internship in the restaurant for a senior class project. Together with Juana and several students, I also organized a club for Spanish-speaking parents who had children in local schools. Juana’s brother catered these events, and I paid for them. Juana served as the moderator, and she and I planned every gathering. Members of my research team and I saw Juana and her siblings at all these events, as well as at local community organizations where they sponsored programs, in church, and during the political campaign of your nephew—who was the first Mexican to run for political office in the town.

All of this constituted a longstanding, 9-year friendship that I developed with you all. But when the time came to write a book about my project in the town (Wortham et al., 2020), I faced a challenge. I needed to write about you, instead of talking to you. I spoke to you about the book, of course. Throughout our project in Marshall, my colleagues and I have worked hard to include participant voices and contribute to projects that served their needs and interests (e.g., Gallo & Wortham, 2012). A couple of your family members expressed reservations about having me discuss certain aspects of their lives, but most were happy to have me tell their stories. My research team and I presented several things that we wrote to you and to others in the town,

and we asked for your feedback before publishing them. Despite your consent, however, I confronted the need to write about you for an academic audience. It is hard to navigate this transition. In writing about you, and not with you, am I disregarding, undermining, or taking advantage of our friendship?

Everyone participates in multiple social spheres. In most cases, it is not a problem being friends with someone in one sphere and then doing different things without them in another. You do many things I have no connection to, and it is fine for me to live my life as a researcher apart from you. But representing your lives in this other sphere nonetheless seems questionable. When I spoke with Juana about this, you were supportive. You said that it is important to have researchers giving accounts of immigration in America, and you said that you had no intention of doing this yourself. You gave me permission to write the book, as long as I avoided certain topics and did not reveal sensitive details.

This is really a question about the nature and purpose of the human sciences. Like all practices, research “makes up people,” as Hacking (1990) shows—it produces certain kinds of subjects and not others (Foucault, 1978; Link et al., 2017). As long as research in psychology and related fields strives to represent human processes and realities, there will be some tension created when scientists represent other people. One could change the nature of academic research—turning it into collaborative activism, for example. But this would reduce its ability to represent the human world and also reduce its credibility. We must recognize how we produce kinds of people in our academic work. We should not imagine that, as researchers, we are immune from the ethical and political implications of representing others. But neither should we imagine that we can work entirely collaboratively with others, given our different positions and goals. Perhaps the best we can do is to live responsibly with the tension between friend, researcher, and research subject. I hope that I have been able to do that in my relationship with you, as well as in my writing.

I suspect that you would react to this letter in at least three ways. First, you would demand responsibility on my part, making sure that I did not invade anyone’s privacy or misrepresent them. Second, I know that you care deeply about the fate of Mexican immigrants to the United States and that both of you spend significant parts

of your professional lives helping other immigrants. You have expressed hope that our research might encourage more humane reactions from longstanding residents and greater opportunities for Mexicans and their children to build lives here. Third, I suspect that you would not be deeply concerned about academic writing and academic contexts, even if they are partly about you, and that you would instead inquire about my family and focus on our relationships. There are more important things to do with one’s time, you might advise me, than writing another book.

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